Christopher I. V. Farmer
LEGAL OPERATIONS · LEGAL-TECH · GENEVA

OPERATING FRAMEWORK

How I run the first 90 days

This is a **repeatable operating model, not a fixed plan**. The mandate sets the emphasis — a CLM rollout, a GRC build, a privacy programme or a regulatory-monitoring pipeline — but the shape of the work is the same: understand before I change anything, earn trust with early wins, build the system on a single source of truth, then embed it so it survives after I have gone. The week ranges below are a default rhythm; I compress or extend them to fit the contract.

Principles: Compliance as an enabler, not a blocker · Regulators as partners · Controls that survive an audit · Human-in-the-loop on every automation · One record, no duplication · Fix the process before automating it · Measure everything.

WEEK 0 · BEFORE DAY ONE **Align** *Start already pointed at the right target.*	• Agree the **mandate, scope and success metrics** in writing with the sponsor — what "done in 90 days" means. • Secure access, tooling and the key stakeholder list; confirm confidentiality, privilege and data-handling boundaries up front. • Request the existing artefacts (contracts, registers, policies, prior audits) so week one is analysis, not chasing.
WEEKS 1–3 **Listen & audit** *Map reality before touching it.*	• Interview the people who actually do the work — legal, ops, finance, engineering, and the internal clients they serve. • Map the current state: intake and triage, the contract lifecycle, the obligation and risk registers, the systems and the hand-offs between them. • Baseline the numbers (cycle times, matter volumes, exceptions, audit-retrieval time) so improvement is provable. • Surface the **single-source-of-truth gaps** and the two or three risks that would hurt most if left alone.
WEEKS 3–6 **Stabilise & quick wins** *Reduce pain, build trust.*	• Fix the highest-pain, lowest-risk items first — a standard template, a cleaner intake form, a missing approval gate. • Stand up the **reporting spine**: a first dashboard the sponsor can actually use, even if fed manually at this stage. • Close the most material compliance gap found in the audit, with a documented, defensible control. • Publish a short roadmap so everyone sees where this is going — momentum is a deliverable.
WEEKS 6–10 **Build & integrate** *Stand up the core system.*	• Configure the core platform for the mandate — templates, intake logic, approval workflows and permissions, playbooks, fallback language and clause libraries. • Wire the integrations over **REST/JSON and webhooks** onto one record, with **human-in-the-loop gates** on anything automated. • Design for auditability from the start: provenance, timestamps, retention and a clean evidence trail.

WEEKS 10–13 **Embed & measure** *Make it stick without me.*	• Train the team, hand over playbooks and a runbook, and move self-service work to the people who own it. • Turn the reporting spine into live executive dashboards — matter volumes, SLA performance, privacy-risk trends, compliance readiness. • Run a **90-day review** against the week-0 metrics and agree the next-quarter roadmap and owners. • Default target: at least one core workflow live and self-service, audit-retrieval down to minutes, and a signed next-quarter roadmap with named owners.

How the emphasis shifts by mandate

Same operating model, different centre of gravity. A few common briefs:

Mandate	Where the weight goes	What "good" looks like at day 90
CLM / contract ops	Intake logic, templates & clause libraries, approval gates, e-signature, playbooks (e.g. a Streamline intake + Juro rollout).	Self-service contracting live for standard paper; legal-review gates enforced; cycle time and volumes on a dashboard.
GRC / risk	Control mapping, obligation register, evidence trails, tooling (OneTrust / ServiceNow GRC).	A live obligation-to-control map; audit evidence retrievable in minutes, not days.
Privacy / data protection	ROPA, DPIA/LIA triggers, SAR workflow, retention, cross-border transfers.	Privacy-by-design gates in intake; DPIAs triggered automatically; SARs on an SLA.
Regulatory monitoring	Python pipelines that flag changes and trigger tasks, approvals and records into risk registers, with board reporting (e.g. Power BI).	Policy changes flagged automatically; board-level reporting and an audit log across sites.

 Christopher I. V. Farmer · Geneva · civfarmer@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/civfarmer